

The seventh element

What “how the State will measure the effectiveness of the corrective action” looks like when it is answered with a number.

Both federal benefit-integrity programs ask the same seven things of a corrective action plan: the finding and the qualifiers used to identify it, the root cause, the action, its status, the responsible party, how implementation will be monitored, and **how the State will measure the effectiveness of the action**. SNAP writes it into 7 CFR 275.17 as a mandatory element with semiannual updates on 1 May and 1 November; Medicaid asks it of every MEQC case-level report. Six of the seven are answered in nearly every plan. The seventh is usually answered with a description of activity, because the only measure most states have is the official rate — which publishes twelve to twenty months later with a sampling interval wide enough to hide any single action. This page shows the difference between a plan that describes and a plan that measures, using one common finding.

One finding, answered two ways

As most plans answer it today	As a plan answers it with a measurement behind the claim (figures illustrative)
<i>“The agency will monitor the effectiveness of the corrective action through ongoing supervisory case reviews and will evaluate results against the next reported payment error rate.”</i>	Finding addressed. Earned income reported at redetermination not carried into the budget (cause code 12; 44% of FY2024 error dollars, 4 of 5 top elements).
What a reviewer can check: nothing until the next official rate publishes, 12 to 20 months later, with a sampling interval of roughly ± 1 point that cannot resolve a single action’s effect from everything else that changed.	Indicator and baseline. Share of completed redeterminations in which every reported income change is applied, from a weekly sample of 60 cases: baseline 71% $\pm$ 6 (Jul-Sep 2026) . Reviewer: named; definition: attached as Annex C, version-dated.
What the state can show at the semiannual update: that reviews occurred, that training was delivered, that the rate went up or down — with no way to attribute the move to this action.	Design, registered before rollout. Action rolls out to 8 of 24 local offices in October, the remaining 16 in January; the indicator is charted for both groups with control limits; a real shift is reported only when a control-chart rule fires, not when a point moves inside the noise.
Effectiveness statement: a description of activity.	Effectiveness statement, semiannual update. “Indicator moved from 71% $\pm$ 6 to 88% $\pm$ 4 in the first-wave offices and stayed at 72% $\pm$ 5 in the others over the same 12 weeks; the shift met rule 1 in week 7. Estimated effect on the element’s error dollars: -38%, interval -22% to -51%. The published rate is not yet available for this period and is not claimed.”

What a reviewer can ask for

A plan that measures carries five things a reviewer can check without being an auditor. None of them requires a tool, a vendor or a change to federal guidance; all of them are within a state’s existing QC and reporting capacity.

- **An indicator with a definition.** What is counted, from what population, how often, by whom — written down, version-dated, and not amended in place.
- **A baseline with an interval.** The indicator’s value before the action, with its margin of error and the period it covers. A number without an interval is a description.
- **A design registered before rollout.** Which units go first, what should move, by when, and what rule will be treated as a real shift. Registered in advance so the result cannot be chosen after the fact.
- **An effect stated with its uncertainty** and stated separately from the published rate. The official measure is reported beside it with its own interval; the plan does not claim to have moved a number that has not yet been published.
- **The two companion measures.** Procedural accuracy (CAPER or its Medicaid equivalent) and application timeliness, charted beside the indicator, so that accuracy is not bought with denials or backlog.

What this is not. It is not a request that federal reviewers evaluate methods; the method stays with the state and its own audit staff. It is the form the seventh answer takes when there is a measurement behind it — the same form a reviewer would accept from a state’s own QC unit.

Drawn from the B-SPC open measurement standard (v2.3, Sep 2026), open-licensed at zeluca.com/b-spc; free to cite; product-independent.